

תשעה באב is a special day in that we focus all of our thoughts, תפילות, and efforts in mourning over the חורבן בית. However, this is not the only time that we do this. We remember ירושלים every single day. R' Yissocher Frand points out that we have other reminders of what happened on תשעה באב, why it happened, and what we have to do about it. He gives an interesting example. When ראש חודש comes out on Sunday, the הפטורה we read is מחר חדש. It seems superficially that the entire connection between the portion of the נביא and ראש חודש is merely the words מחר חדש. However, Rabbi Frand, quoting Rav Shimshon Schwab, asks why חז"ל would do that, especially since we never skip a הפטורה on a Shabbos unless there's a יום טוב? Why would we lein a completely different הפטורה just because it says מחר חדש? He says no, there's a much deeper and profound insight into why the חכמים required us to lein this הפטורה.

What do we say in the מוסף of ראש חודש? ציון Hashem, please establish a new מזבח in ציון, the בית המקדש. We're davening that the בית המקדש should be rebuilt. We allude to the fact that we are still here. Another ראש חודש has come and gone, and we still cannot offer a מוסף קרבן. We can daven מוסף, but we cannot bring a קרבן מוסף because we don't have a בית המקדש. Now that's interesting. Every time that ראש חודש comes out on a Sunday, the חכמים are reminding us, you know why tomorrow we're going to only daven מוסף and not bring a קרבן מוסף? Because of what happened in that הפטורה. What happened in that הפטורה of מחר חדש? שאל המלך wants to know why דוד didn't come to the סעודה. He asks his son, יונתן, "Why hasn't בן ישי come, not yesterday and not today?" It's such an innocent question, but it doubles as a question for us and reverberates throughout all of the דורות: Why hasn't בן ישי come? Why hasn't משיח come? The answer is in the הפטורה - because of חנם. It's שנאת חנם that caused the destruction of the בית המקדש, which is ongoing and is a cause of all our צרות today. That is what שאל demonstrated towards דוד המלך. Every time we have a מחר חדש, we should wake up and remind ourselves why hasn't בן ישי come. That is the message of that fantastic insight in מחר חדש.

The following story has nothing to do with what's been said until now - it's just a wonderful example of what a Yid who had אהבת ישראל looked like. Someone who nearly lived in our lifetime: R' Aryeh Levine, the צדיק of ירושלים. It was a scorching hot Friday afternoon in ירושלים. Dressed in his Shabbos clothes, the צדיק of ירושלים, Rabbi Aryeh Levine, was making his rounds, going to all the shops and making sure they all closed on time for Shabbos. He got to the ice cream shop, and there was a long line of customers snaking around the corner. It appeared that the owner had no intention of closing up anytime soon. It was almost time for lecht benching. R' Aryeh understood it would be very difficult for the owner to pull himself away from all of these customers and this business, but Shabbos was Shabbos. R' Aryeh walked to the front of the store, sat down, and put his shtreimel on the table. The owner understood why he was there, R' Aryeh being a familiar figure from his weekly pre-Shabbos rounds.

The owner looked at all the customers. He was not going to lose out on this business, he decided. It was not every day he could sell out his entire stock in less than one hour. Then he heard Rav Aryeh in a soft voice, "What can I tell you? You are facing a very hard test. Still, Shabbos is Shabbos." He got up slowly, put his shtreimel back on his head, shook the hand of the owner like an old friend, and hurried out of the store. After Rav Aryeh had walked quite a distance, he took a glance behind him. The line had dispersed. People were walking off in all directions. The owner was shoos the last of the crowd away and locking up his shop. Rav Aryeh breathed deeply and shook his head. "I envy that shopkeeper," he thought to himself. "He succeeded in passing a difficult test."

A few years later, the store owner met Rav Aryeh and told him, "I will never forget the words you said to me that Friday afternoon. You felt I was facing a very hard test. You understood what I was going through. The words 'Shabbos is Shabbos' that you whispered and didn't yell penetrated my heart."



I felt you were feeling the pain of the holy Shabbos. At that moment, I made up my mind that I would not cause a Jew like you pain, and I immediately locked up my store.” Rav Aryeh grabbed his arm and said, “כלל ישראל.”

That’s what אהבת ישראל is, to talk to people, not to judge them, not to talk down to them, and certainly not to yell at them, but to talk from your heart. And what comes from the heart will go into the heart.

